Social Presence and Online Engagement in Learning: Faculty Development Session

Supporting Online Teaching at Bahir Dar University

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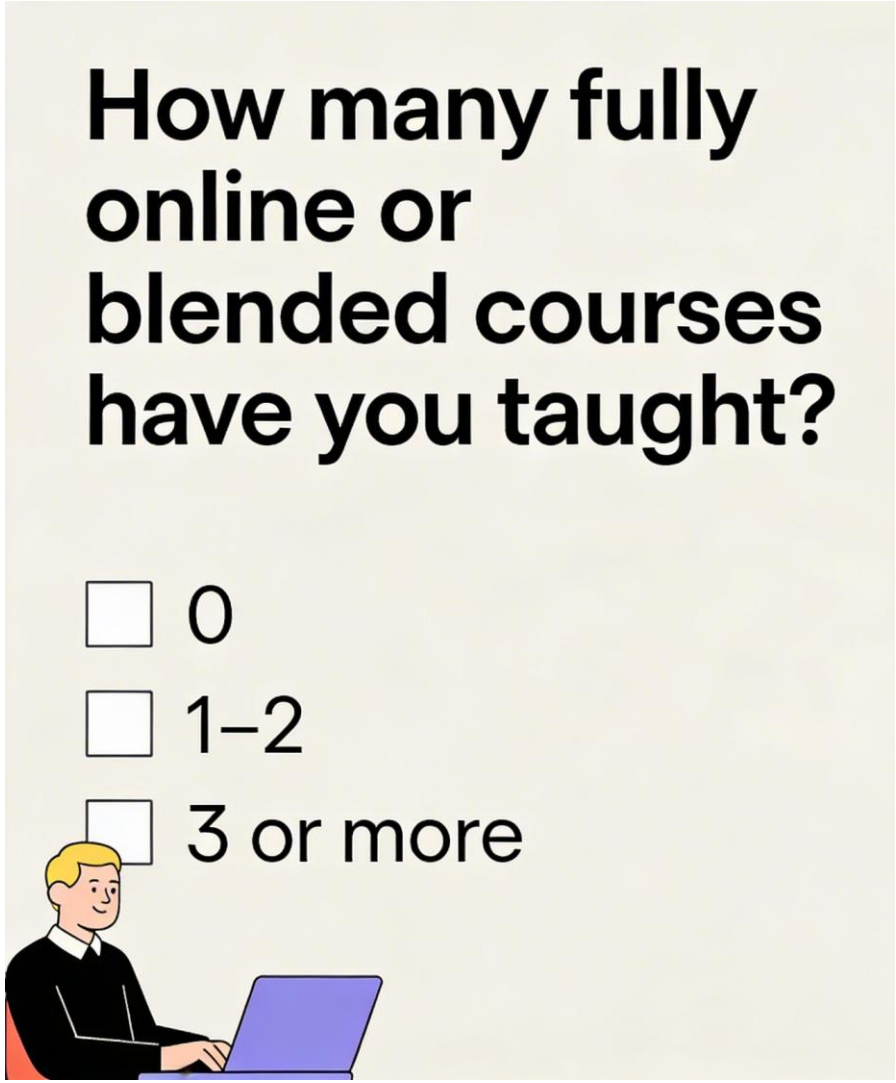
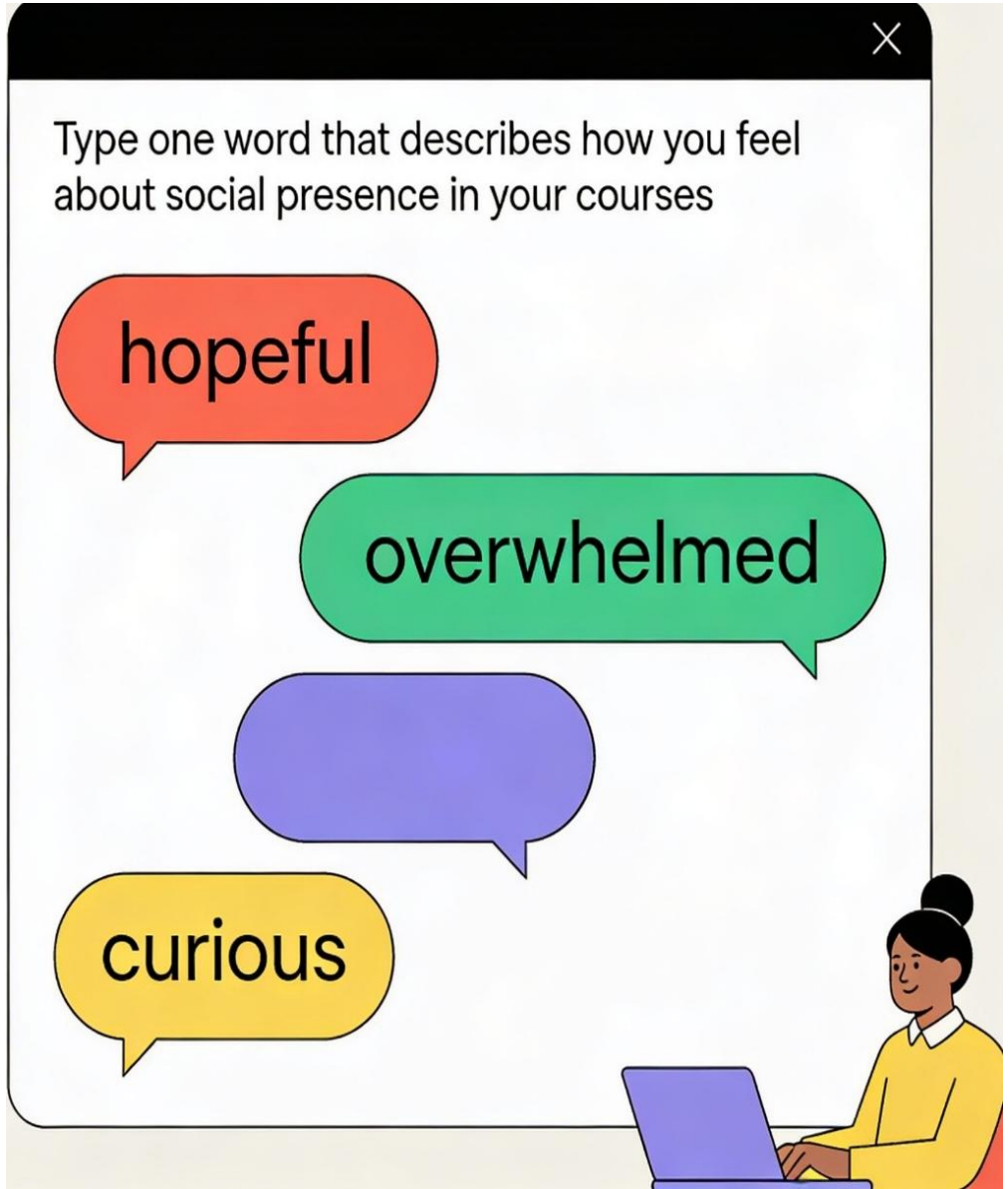
Quick Check-In: Your Online Teaching Experience





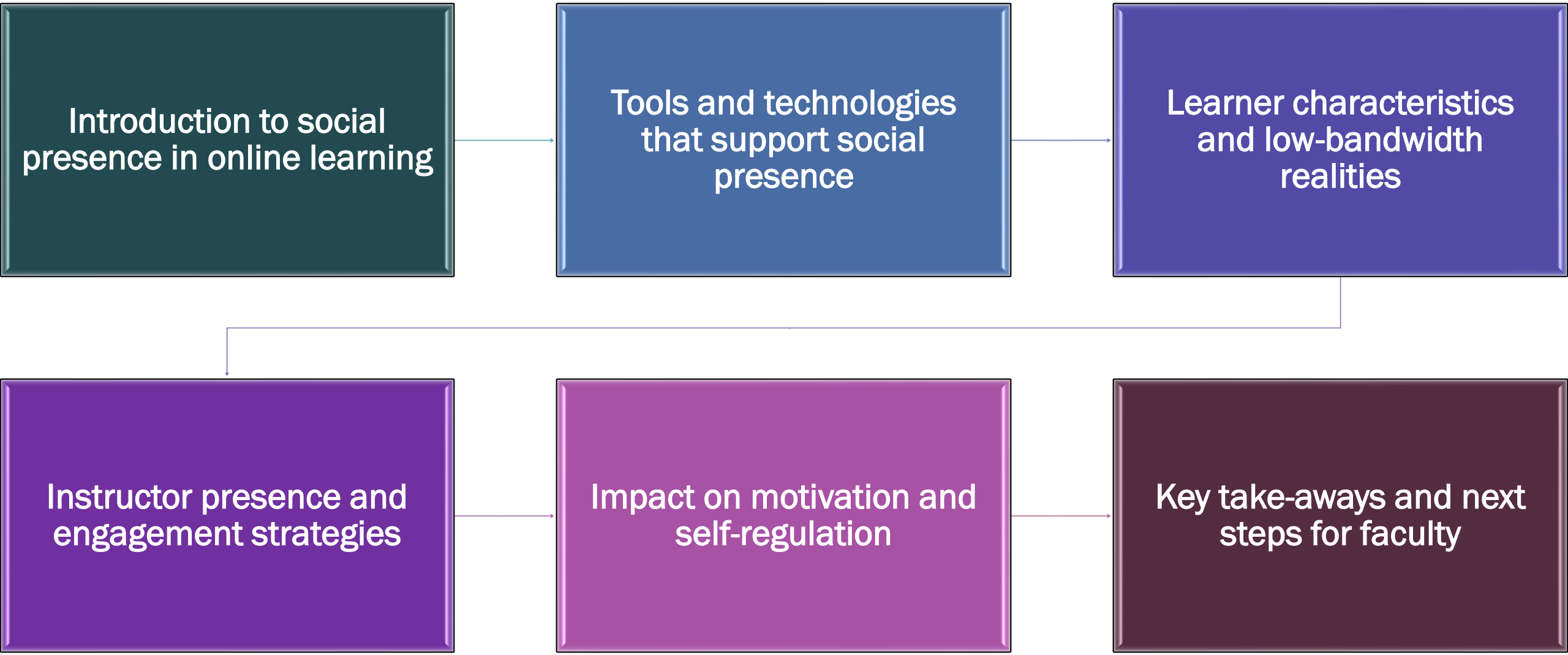
Supporting Online Teaching at Bahir Dar University

Purpose: Help faculty design online courses that feel human, interactive, and supportive for students.

By the end, you will be able to:

- Define social presence in online learning.
- Identify common learner challenges at Bahir Dar University.
- Apply practical strategies to build presence, engagement, and self-regulation in low-bandwidth contexts.

Session Roadmap



Social Presence and Online Engagement

Social presence is the extent to which learners and instructors experience each other as authentic, visible individuals within an online course community.

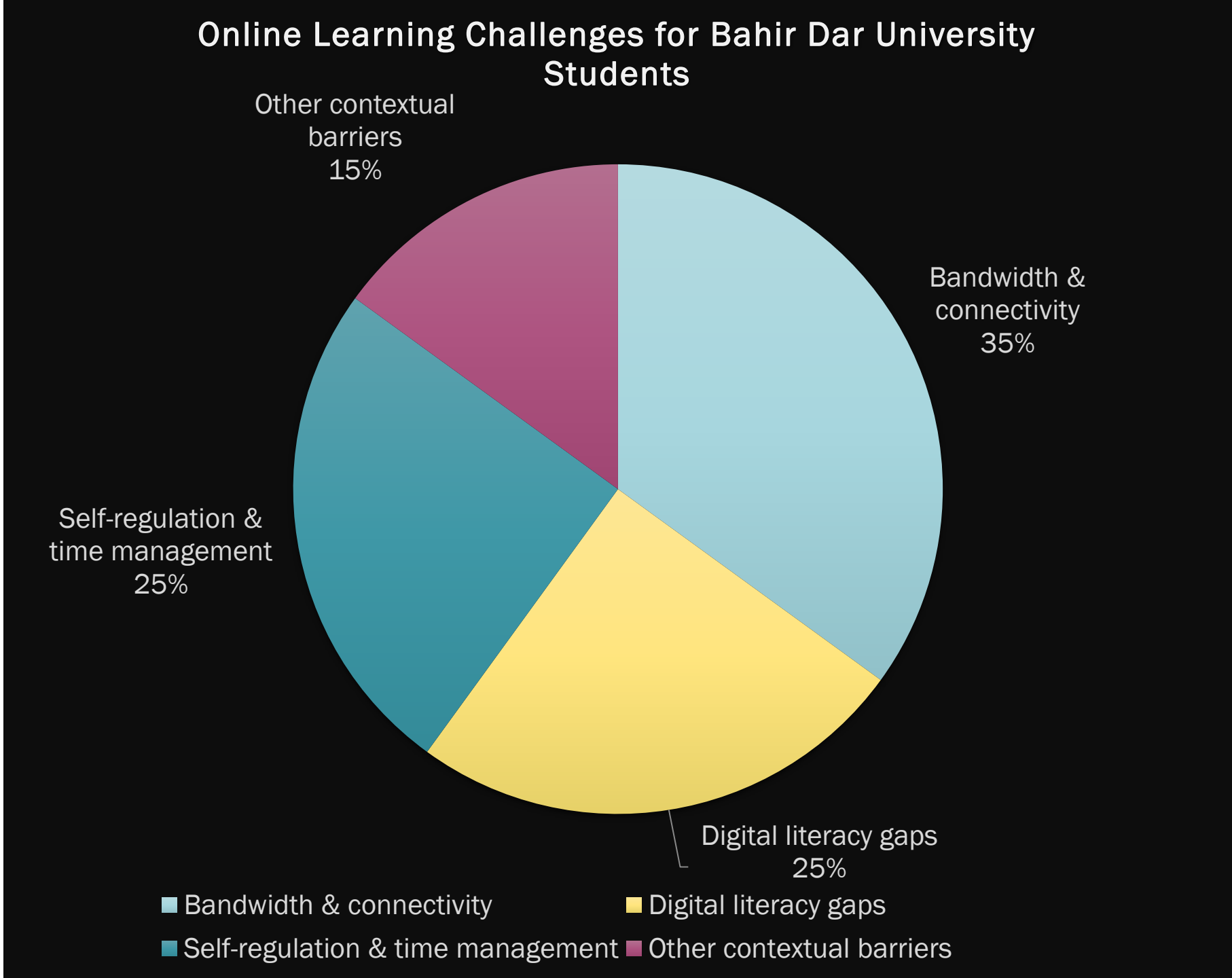
When social presence is high, students feel supported, more willing to participate, and more likely to stay engaged and complete the course successfully.

In traditional classrooms, interaction happens naturally through physical presence and spontaneous conversation, while in online settings it must be deliberately cultivated through tools such as discussions, live sessions, and messaging spaces.

Institutional Tools and Technologies

e-SHE LMS

Bahir Dar University Learners in Online Contexts



Instructor Presence & Engagement

Instructor presence

Be visibly present each week with welcome notes, check-ins, and closing summaries so students feel the instructor is “there” with them.

Use students’ names in forums and messages, and acknowledge their questions and efforts to build trust and connection.

Share brief personal/contextual examples (from Ethiopian higher education or local realities) to humanize the online space.

Instructor engagement

Facilitate discussions with open questions, prompt follow-ups, and short summaries that connect different students’ ideas.

Give timely, constructive feedback on assignments (within a stated timeframe), focusing on what was done well and what to improve next.

Use short, low-bandwidth videos or voice notes plus clear announcements (via LMS and messaging apps) to clarify tasks and encourage persistence.

Motivation, Self-Regulation, and Social Presence

Consistent instructor messages, check-ins, and acknowledgement of students' efforts help counter feelings of isolation and keep learners motivated despite connectivity constraints.

Social presence supports self-regulated learning by creating a supportive climate where students feel safe to ask questions, share challenges, and receive guidance on how to plan and manage their study time.

Ethiopian studies using the Community of Inquiry framework show that stronger teaching and **social presence** are associated with improved engagement and deeper learning, suggesting that intentional social presence practices can enhance outcomes in universities like Bahir Dar.

Key Takeaway

Social presence is essential for making online courses feel supportive and community-oriented, especially when students learn mostly via mobile and unstable internet.

Simple, low-bandwidth tools (text forums, messaging apps, brief audio/video messages) can create strong presence and interaction without requiring high connectivity.

Clear instructor presence (check-ins, timely feedback, using students' names) helps students stay motivated and more self-regulated.

Choose one small change to try in your next course (e.g., weekly audio check-in or structured discussion prompt) and evaluate its impact with your students.

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